

The EU is interfering in Armenia's internal affairs: Garnik Danielyan on providing 15 million euros

According to Garnik Danielyan, the authorities will use the money received from the EU solely to condemn the opposition.

YEREVAN, December 15 – Sputnik: The European Union is interfering in Armenia's internal affairs. Garnik Danielyan, a member of the Armenia parliamentary faction, said this in a conversation with reporters at the National Assembly today, referring to the EU's intention to provide Armenia with 15 million euros.

On December 2, Yerevan and Brussels **signed a new partnership document**. The High Representative of the European Union for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy, Kaia Kalas, announced that the EU will provide Armenia with 15 million euros to implement several projects, including mine clearance work, as well as support in the context of hybrid warfare. Danielyan recalled that the EU interfered in the Moldovan elections, which changed the results.

"Nikol Pashinyan, during his meeting with Moldovan President Maia Sandu, highly appreciated the work done in Moldova. And what happened in Moldova? The EU, in the same scenario, under the name of hybrid warfare, provided quite serious support during the Moldovan elections, and also banned parties from participating. They created problems with voters, in particular, they did not give Moldovan citizens living in Russia the opportunity to participate in the elections, but on the contrary, there was no obstacle for those living in Europe," said Garnik Danielyan.

According to the MP, the Armenian authorities want to "snatch" money from the EU for their domestic needs. He is sure that the authorities will use the money received under the guise of hybrid warfare exclusively to condemn the opposition forces.

Poverty or trafficking?: The visible and hidden aspects of child begging

21:15 16.05.2026 (Updated: 23:03 16.05.2026)



AI-generated image: Child begging
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A child standing on the street is not always just someone in need of help. Sometimes he or she is a participant in a dangerous chain of exploitation. How does a child become a beggar, how does the street become a “gateway to the criminal world?” Sputnik Armenia tried to find the answers to these questions.

The Armenian Constitution, laws, and international conventions protect minors from begging and vagrancy, but the cases of children begging on Yerevan’s central streets, in subways, in church courtyards, or near cafes prove otherwise. This phenomenon is often perceived as a reflection of poverty, but from a legal and human rights perspective, this is not just a social issue. When a child is used to collect money, especially on a regular basis or under the supervision of an adult, we are dealing not with a “family problem,” but with potential child exploitation.

Reports on the protection of children's rights clearly state that forcing children to beg is not only a social disaster, but also a serious crime that disrupts the normal course of a child's development. In Armenia, this

phenomenon is often viewed as a consequence of poverty, but from a legal perspective it falls within the realm of exploitation and trafficking.

The Office of the Human Rights Defender of the Republic of Armenia also considers poverty to be one of the fundamental reasons for child begging. In response to a query from Sputnik Armenia, the Office of the Human Rights Defender stated that the Human Rights Defender's regular monitoring shows that children growing up in poverty often face violations of a number of rights related to healthy food, hygiene items, housing, healthcare, education, and access to cultural values.

Brother beats sister and her 2 children to beg: how people end up outside

"Poverty is also one of the main reasons for involving children in begging. The monitoring conducted by the Human Rights Defender during 2025 indicates that the level of poverty, including child poverty, continues to be high in the Republic of Armenia, especially in the regions. Regarding some cases of begging, the Defender's staff has recorded that the problem is also directly related to the parents' low parenting skills and low legal awareness. There are often cases when children engage in begging with the knowledge and sometimes with the instigation of their parents," the response states.

What do official statistics show?

The 2025 rate of begging or forced begging by minors increased by 5 cases compared to 2024. The response of the RA Ministry of Internal Affairs to Sputnik Armenia states that the number of cases of begging or forced begging by minors, including those related to trafficking, was 9 in 2024, and 14 in 2025.



Child begging is on the rise in Armenia

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“According to the data of the Crime Statistics and Research Center of the Ministry of Internal Affairs, in 2024, one proceeding was initiated under Part 2, Point 3 of Article 189 of the Criminal Code of the Republic of Armenia (trafficking or exploitation of a child or a helpless person) and two under Part 2, Point 4 of Article 189 of the Criminal Code of the Republic of Armenia. In 2025, two criminal proceedings were initiated under Part 2, Point 4 of Article 189 of the Criminal Code of the Republic of Armenia against parents or other persons who forced children to engage in begging,” the Ministry of Internal Affairs replied to [Sputnik Armenia](#) . According to the ministry, in 2024, 3 minors were registered with the police for begging, and in 2025, 2 minors. Data for 2026 has not yet been summarized.

Yerevan couple trafficked, beat, and threatened beggars

During the same period, applications to the Ombudsman's office increased by 3. The office responded to us that in 2024-2025, they received 8 applications regarding cases of begging and exploitation of minors. By the way, international reports prove that official figures in Armenia cannot fully reflect the real picture, especially when it comes to pressure on the child within the family or community silence.

International reports link the problem to trafficking

The US Department of Labor's 2024 **assessment** of Armenia states that children in Armenia are subjected to the worst forms of labor, including commercial sexual exploitation, forced begging, forced street vending, forced labor in shops, agriculture, and domestic work.

The Council of Europe's GRETA group also recorded in its **report** on Armenia that 68 victims of trafficking were identified in Armenia between 2017 and 2021, with sexual exploitation, labor exploitation, and forced begging being common forms of exploitation. GRETA also stressed that the actual number of victims is likely higher, as victims often avoid identification due to shame, stigma, ignorance of their rights, and distrust of authorities.

Children selling napkins, roses, and the wrong "help" from citizens

Colonel Nelly Duryan, former head of the Department for the Protection of Minors' Rights and Combating Domestic Violence at the Police, has always encountered the issue of child begging in her work. In an interview with Sputnik Armenia, she noted that the problem has psychological and social layers.

Often, begging is disguised as petty trade, selling napkins, icons, or roses. According to Duryan, there are honest children who really want to work and help their families, but for the most part, it is a form of begging.

Criticizing the citizens' approach, he noted that the compassion characteristic of Armenians sometimes harms the child.

"Our citizens give money to a child and say, 'Keep the napkin, you don't need it.' That's not good. The child needs to be helped, but not in that way. By doing so, we instill in the child the idea that it is possible to earn money easily," he said.

Duryan noted that begging quickly becomes a way of life for a child.

According to him, when a child earns money easily on the street several times, a character trait is formed in him that constantly pushes him to the street.

"When a child takes money once, a second, a third time, it already forms a character in him. He gets used to the status that someone can insult him or say a bad word. This is a habit full of very serious consequences," he said.

According to the Colonel, the reasons for children's begging vary: sometimes children take the money home to help a single parent, but more often they spend it on their own entertainment, games, food, or even cigarettes.

"Unfortunately, begging is often organized. Yes, we have discovered cases where children were formed into groups to encourage them to beg. A group of 3-5 children is encouraged by adults or 17-18-year-old youth to beg. In other words, the children collect money and give it to them," Duryan explained.

The reality behind the glass: the number of begging children has increased

He reminded that there were times when children engaged in begging solely to raise money for computer games.

"We would go to specific places where these games were and find kids who had already spent half of their money on games," he added.

Colonel Nelly Duryan specifically emphasized that for a child on the street, begging is only the beginning, which often has a criminal continuation.

According to her, vagrancy and begging open the door to the criminal world, as the child becomes a target for criminal elements and loses moral boundaries.

"The child, staying on the street and engaging in begging, finds himself in a situation that over the years leads him to a criminal path. He begins to engage in theft, may become involved in the distribution and use of drugs. This is the dangerous threshold after which the child turns into a criminal," Duryan noted.

State levers and the need for 24-hour work

A one-time intervention, according to the police colonel, does not solve the problem, as consistent work by the police, social workers, and the school is necessary. If the parent is unaware of the child's actions, the issue is easily resolved, but if the parent is the one instigating it, then in-depth social programs and support for the family are necessary.

"We would find the child, bring him to the department, talk to him, take him home, and take him home. By the time our police officer returned to the regional department, the child would have already arrived at the Opera House ahead of us and beg for money again. If consistent work is not carried out for at least one day, the number of children on the street will increase, because they involve each other in this matter. The police officers find him, then a social worker should be involved, a psychologist should work with the family, and they should go and check whether the child is attending school normally," said Duryan.

What do the Constitution and the Criminal Code of the Republic of Armenia say?

Article 37 of the Constitution of the Republic of Armenia stipulates that in matters concerning children, the interests of the child shall be given primary

consideration, and children left without parental care shall be under the care and protection of the state. The Constitution also places on parents the obligation to take care of the upbringing, education, health, and full development of their child.

The RA Law "On the Rights of the Child" guarantees the child the right to life, health, necessary living conditions, and protection from violence. The same law prohibits subjecting a child to violence or treatment degrading their dignity.

The Criminal Code views begging as engaging in antisocial behavior.

Child sexual abuse or sex trafficking: expert on Vedi's case

Article 240 of the Criminal Code of the Republic of Armenia provides for criminal liability for a person over the age of 18 who regularly involves a child in vagrancy or begging. If this is done by a person who is responsible for the upbringing, care, or treatment of the child, the punishment is harsher.

But there is an important line here. If a child's begging is organized for the purpose of exploitation, the issue of child trafficking or exploitation may already arise. Article 189 of the Criminal Code considers the exploitation of a child or placing him in a state of exploitation as a serious crime, providing for 7 to 10 years of imprisonment, and in aggravating circumstances, up to 15 years.

What do the relevant authorities say?

The response from the Office of the Ombudsman to Sputnik Armenia states that the results of the monitoring indicate that in 2025, the problems related to the detection of cases of begging and vagrancy continued to remain relevant.

The Ministry of Internal Affairs assured us that the police are continuously carrying out relevant work to identify minors engaged in begging, as well as those who involve them in similar illegal activities, and to take necessary actions, by conducting inspection tours and obtaining information, in cooperation with other interested organizations in the sector.

Both the Ministry of Internal Affairs and the Ombudsman's Office have noted that they are actively cooperating with the Ministry of Labor and Social Affairs of the Republic of Armenia, the Unified Social Service, and the Guardianship and Trusteeship Body.

In this context, the response to our written inquiry from the Ministry of Labor and Social Affairs of the Republic of Armenia is most noteworthy. We asked the Ministry to answer the following questions:

1.

What are the ministry's current programs and projects for social support for underage beggars and their families?

2.

How many children were resocialized or received social assistance from begging cases in 2024 and 2025, and what are the resocialization centers?

3.

How does the Ministry cooperate with the police and anti-trafficking agencies to prevent forced begging?

4.

Are there any statistics on the connection between family poverty and street exploitation of children, and what new programs are planned for 2026?

5.

What are the obstacles to removing children from begging and providing social support to their families?

Of the 5 questions posed by Sputnik Armenia, the Ministry of Labor and Social Affairs of the Republic of Armenia answered only one (What are the Ministry's current programs and projects for social support for underage beggars and their families?), noting that the other questions are outside the scope of the Ministry's authority.

The ministry's response states that the 6 child and family support centers operating under the Ministry of Social Affairs (designed for 600 children) and non-governmental organizations providing services delegated by the state in the form of grants provide socio-psychological, socio-rehabilitative, legal and other needs-based services to children in difficult life situations. The ministry added that minors identified as begging and vagrancy in Yerevan and the regions also receive professional services at these day centers.